

CCD

Creative Curriculum Designer

Exceptional lessons start with connection

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The facts

The State of Creative Education in England

The facts on creative education in England - for funding, partnership and development.

Creative education in England is at a tipping point. Exceptional lessons start with connection - and CCDesigner makes that connection usable day to day.

Creative education has contracted over the long term, with a clear entitlement gap linked to place and disadvantage. New government plans - curriculum reform, Turn It Up, the National Centre - and free national resources create space to rebuild. CCDesigner is the practical layer: plan, share resources, reach cold spots, and evidence how materials are used.

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What's inside

Eleven stages, matching the live index. On screen, tap a stage to jump there. Superscript numbers in the text point to the official sources at the end. The same pages print cleanly.

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01
EYFS

Creative learning in the early years should be child-shaped, exploratory and not limited to a typical classroom model.[11]

The Early Years Foundation Stage statutory framework places Expressive Arts and Design at the heart of how young children invent, communicate and make sense of the world - through music, movement, role-play, materials and stories.[11]

When early arts experiences are thin or adult-directed only, the entitlement gap starts before Key Stage 1. Strong EYFS practice builds the confidence, belonging and creative habits that later enrichment and arts pathways depend on.[11][16]

> *"CCDesigner will give early-years and primary teachers reusable creative blocks, partner resources and planning that respects child-led learning - without forcing a secondary classroom model onto Reception."*

Child-shaped creative learning

- Play first - Children help shape what they explore; creative subjects need room beyond desks and worksheets[11]
- EAD - Expressive Arts and Design: invent, sing, move, role-play and use materials with purpose[11]
- Continuity - Early confidence in music, drama and dance feeds later arts and enrichment participation[16]

Why EYFS matters for enrichment

The DfE Enrichment Framework applies from age 5, but the habits of access start earlier. Schools that treat arts as optional bolt-ons in Reception struggle to meet later expectations for arts and culture, partnership and inclusive participation.[12][16]

- Start early - Belonging, confidence and social connection linked to enrichment begin in the early years[16]
- Arts & culture - One of five enrichment areas: music, dance, theatre, museums and galleries[14]
- Access - Special-school participation already lags mainstream - inclusive early practice matters[16]

02

Primary / KS1-KS2

Arts time is already unequal before secondary - independent schools report far more hours than state schools, and schools with more pupils on free school meals are more likely to have cut hours.[2]

Primary Teacher Tapp / CLA 2026: 47% of independent vs 6% of state primary teachers report more than 2.5 hours of arts per week. About one in four report less than an hour.[2]

Subject leads: Art & Design 89%, Music 84%, Drama 9%, Dance 5%. 43% of primary teachers report that their school works with no external partners to deliver the arts curriculum.[2]

Teachers in the highest-FSM vs lowest-FSM schools reporting reduced arts hours: 31% vs 22%.[2]

Primary teachers reporting more than 2.5 hours of arts per week



Teacher Tapp / CLA Report Card 2026 - survey, not a census.

> *"Where generalists carry the arts - especially in higher-need schools - reusable activity blocks and Partner Hubs put excellent practice within reach, without waiting for local specialist capacity."*

Primary hours

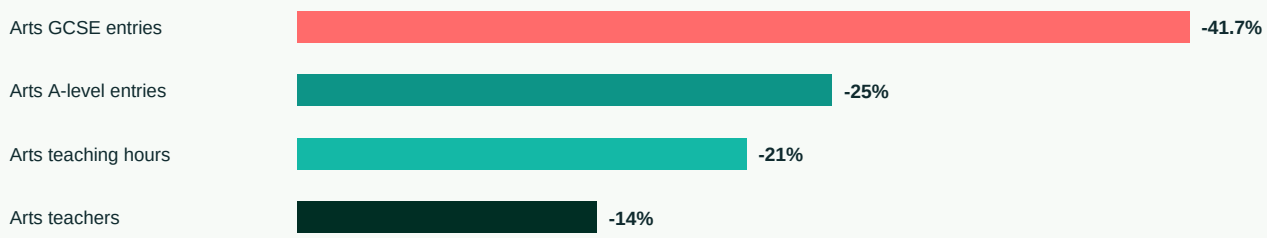
- 47% vs 6% - Independent vs state >2.5 hrs arts / week[2]
- ~1 in 4 - Primary teachers with less than an hour of arts / week[2]
- 43% - No external partners to deliver the arts curriculum[2]

03

Secondary

For more than a decade the school system narrowed around a core academic suite - arts pathways were devalued, hours and teachers fell, and take-up still tracks who can afford to stay in.[1][2]

Long-term contraction in arts education



CLA Report Cards 2024 and 2026.

CLA links the long decline to policy focus (2010-2024) on a narrow range of subject areas that systematically devalued arts in the state sector.[1][2] Arts teaching hours fell 21% between 2011/12 and 2022/23 (excluding Dance, which CLA notes is not consistently reported). Arts teacher headcount was 14% lower than in 2010.[1]

Access to arts qualifications still tracks disadvantage (DfE Tables 18-19) - economically deprived areas feel the curriculum squeeze first.[5]

> *"CCDesigner will support teachers inside a narrowed curriculum - keeping planning cumulative and partnership reachable where specialist capacity and exam pathways thin out, including in higher-need schools."*

Teachers

- -21% - Arts teaching hours (CLA Report Card 2024)[1]
- -14% - Arts teacher headcount (CLA Report Card 2024)[1]

04

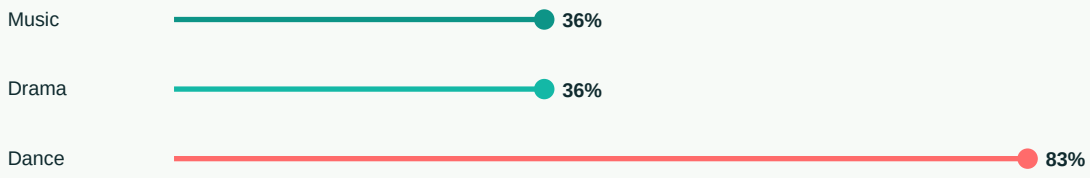
GCSE

Many schools show no GCSE Music, Drama or Dance entries - "no entries" does not mean "not taught", but pathways are thinner where disadvantage is higher.[1]

Arts GCSE entries were 41.7% lower in 2024/25 than in 2009/10.[2]

In 2024/25, 36% of schools had no GCSE Music entries, 36% no Drama, and 83% no Dance. In 2022/23 those figures were 42%, 41% and 84%.[1][2]

Schools with no GCSE entries, 2024/25



CLA Report Card 2026. "No entries" does not mean "not taught".

> *"Where GCSE pathways thin out, cumulative planning and Partner Hub resources keep specialist routes reachable for teachers and students - including in schools that no longer enter exams."*

GCSE entries

Ofqual provisional summer 2026 vs 2025:[4]

- Art +2.7%
- Drama -0.9%
- Music -1.3%
- Performing / Expressive Arts +1.2%
- -41.7% - Arts GCSE entries (CLA Report Card 2026 · 2009/10-2024/25)[2]
- 36% / 36% / 83% - Schools with no GCSE Music / Drama / Dance (2024/25)[2]
- 54% vs 21% - No GCSE Music - most vs least deprived LA fifth[2]

05

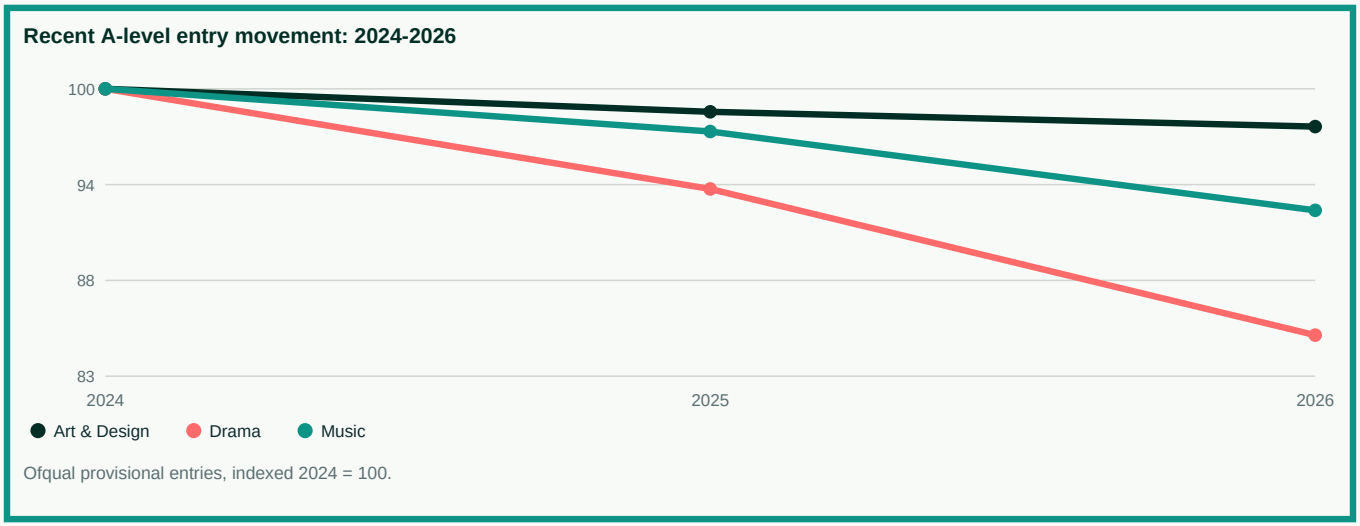
A-level

After GCSE, the arts pathway thins again - and in the most deprived areas it is a smaller share of A-levels.[1][2]

Arts A-level entries have fallen 25% between 2011/12 and 2024/25.[2] Arts share of A-levels: 3.8% vs 5.9% in most vs least deprived fifths.[2]

Ofqual provisional summer 2026 vs 2025 (all A-levels +2.9%):[4]

- Drama -9.5%
- Music -4.9%
- Art -1.0%



> *"Where A-level arts thin out, cumulative planning and shared Partner Hub resources keep specialist pathways reachable - so place and income are less decisive for what teachers can offer."*

A-level entries

- -25% - Arts A-level entries (CLA Report Card 2026 · 2011/12-2024/25)[2]
- 3.8% vs 5.9% - Arts share of A-levels - most vs least deprived[2]

06

University / HE

Creative arts degrees are being closed to new students, suspended, or folded into larger faculties - while take-up falls and the squeeze hits economically deprived areas hardest.

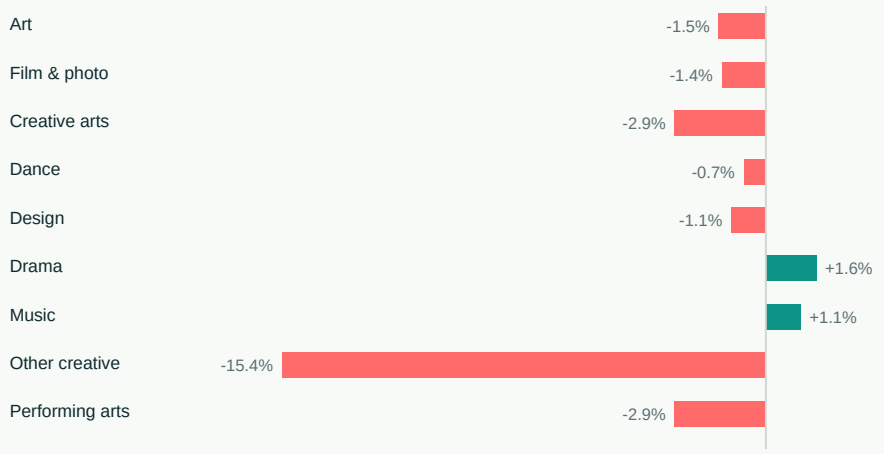
Domestic Creative Arts & Design undergraduates edged down while the wider undergraduate cohort rose (HESA via CLA 2026).[9] In that same university year, Drama (+1.6%) and Music (+1.1%) ticked up - that is not the school-exam fall (A-level Drama -9.5%, Music -4.9%).[4 9] CLA finds steep collapses at individual providers - University College Birmingham -85%, Wolverhampton -58%, St Mary's -51% (2020/21-2024/25) - concentrated in modern universities that educate students from low-participation neighbourhoods.[2] Some providers have lost around two-thirds of Creative Arts & Design academic staff (including Roehampton, Kent and Cumbria).[2]

Several universities have closed or paused music degrees for new students. Kent, Northumbria and Oxford Brookes have closed courses or stopped new intake; Nottingham has suspended 2026/27 recruitment pending a closure decision.[23]

OfS high-cost subject funding for creative and performing arts falls from £12.9 million to £0 in 2026/27 - a 100% cut to Price Group C1.2. That is not all OfS or government support: the Performing Arts Specialist Initiative remains at £9.6 million, and world-leading specialist-provider funding continues.[24]

That sits on top of a school curriculum era that narrowed accountability toward a core academic suite and devalued arts pathways from 14 - so lower GCSE and A-level take-up feeds thinner university demand.[1 2]

University students, 2023/24-2024/25 - not school exams



HESA domestic undergraduates via CLA 2026 Detailed Analysis.

> *"To meet the decline upstream - before courses close or combine - CCDesigner will keep specialist planning and Partner Hub resources in teachers' hands earlier, so geography and household resources are less decisive before students apply."*

HE markers

- -0.5% vs +0.6% - Creative Arts & Design domestic undergrads vs wider undergraduate cohort (2023/24->2024/25)[9]
- Nine of ten - Largest Creative Arts & Design undergraduate falls at modern universities[2]
- UCB / Wolverhampton / St Mary's - -85% / -58% / -51% Creative Arts & Design domestic undergrads (2020/21-2024/25)[2]
- £12.9m -> £0 - OfS high-cost subject funding for creative and performing arts (2025/26->2026/27) - a 100% cut; specialist and initiative funding continues[24]
- £9.6m - Performing Arts Specialist Initiative still allocated in 2026/27[24]

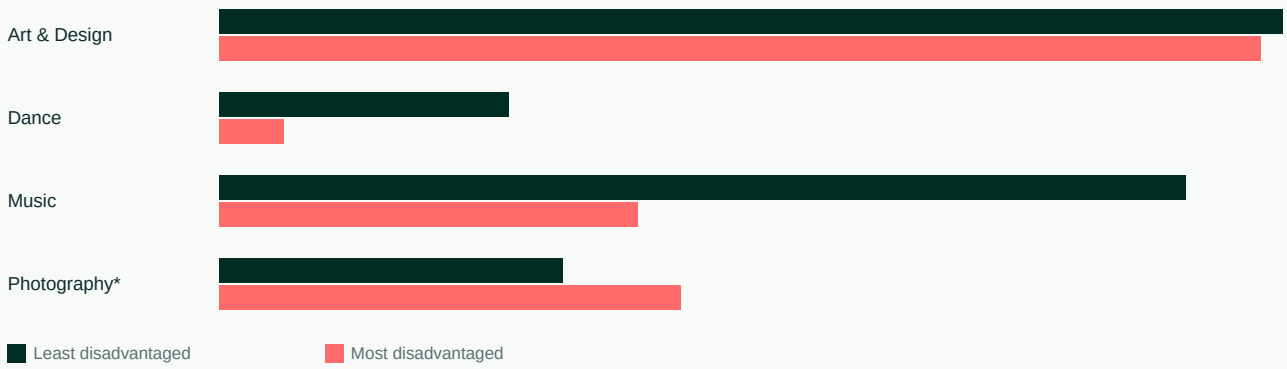
07

Cold spots · place & income

Where you live, and what your school can spend, still decides how much art you get. That gap starts early and travels upwards. Regions with the highest rates of free school meals - the West Midlands and the North East - have among the lowest arts shares of GCSE and A-level entries.[2] Schools in the most deprived fifth of local authorities are far more likely to have no GCSE Music entries (54% vs 21%), and no GCSE Drama entries (59% vs 17%).[2]

FSM-eligible pupils are under-represented in arts GCSEs and in several arts A-levels (including Music, Dance and Drama).[2][3] That school pipeline feeds university demand. Disadvantaged students are more likely to live at home while studying - so geography and parental income keep shaping arts opportunity after 18.[2]

Access to arts qualifications differs by disadvantage



DfE Curriculum & Assessment Review annex, Table 19, 2024/25. *Photography is Table 18.

> *"CCDesigner will widen reach into cold spots - surfacing Partner Hub resources and reusable practice for teachers in higher-need and lower-participation areas, so outstanding materials are shared beyond postcode and parental income."*

Cold-spot markers

- 54% vs 21% - No GCSE Music - most vs least deprived LA fifth[2]
- 59% vs 17% - No GCSE Drama - most vs least deprived LA fifth[2]
- 3.8% vs 5.9% - Arts share of A-levels - most vs least deprived[2]
- West Midlands / North East - Highest FSM rates; among lowest regional arts GCSE / A-level shares[2]
- Nine of ten - Largest Creative Arts & Design undergraduate falls are at modern universities[2][9]

08

Enrichment Framework

After the bell, music, drama and dance are often how a child first finds a place they want to stay. The Enrichment Framework (June 2026) asks every school and college to treat that offer as part of a good education - not a nice extra if the timetable allows.[12]

It is non-statutory guidance for England. It applies to primary, secondary, special and alternative provision, sixth forms and colleges, and to organisations delivering enrichment. Enrichment covers co-curricular and extra-curricular experiences, in or beyond the school day, by staff or external partners.[12][14]

The five areas are civic engagement; arts and culture; nature, outdoors and adventure; sport and physical activity; and wider life and future skills. Schools use a 1-4 self-assessment scale (identifying -> sustaining and stretching) plus an action-planning template for targets, responsibility, monitoring, success criteria, timings and resources.[12][13]

In 2024-25, 75% of schools offered musical performance (orchestra, choir and similar). Separately, parent- and pupil-reported participation in at least one extracurricular activity was 72% at KS1-3, 60% at KS4, and 45% in special schools. Evidence links enrichment with belonging, confidence, wellbeing and social connection, while remaining cautious about causation.[16]

> *"A framework can set expectations, but change depends on capacity, connections and usable systems - not another compliance burden."*

Reported enrichment participation, summer term 2024-25



DfE Evidence on enrichment in schools and colleges.

The eight benchmarks

- Strategically aligned - connect enrichment to curriculum intent and school priorities[13]
- Broad and well-rounded - cover the five enrichment areas[13]
- Well communicated - celebrate participation and achievement[13]
- Shaped by community and student voice[13]
- Accessible and engaging for all - including SEND and disadvantaged pupils[13]
- Works with external partners - local, national and virtual[13]
- Focused on intended outcomes and their measurement[13]
- Continuously reviewed and improved[13]

Why this matters for CCDesigner

Benchmark 6 is an unusually close match: find partners; use expertise beyond school staff; review partnership work;

signpost opportunities beyond the school. Music Hub and arts-organisation pages, trusted resources, CPD, events, calendar and "add to planning" can provide that infrastructure.[15][20]

CCDesigner also has a credible contribution to Benchmarks 1 (curriculum intent), 3 (clear communication), 5 (access barriers and adaptations), 7 (outcomes and proportionate evidence) and 8 (feedback and improvement over time).[12]

- 75% - Schools offering musical performance (2024-25)[16]
- 72% / 60% / 45% - Reported participation - KS1-3 / KS4 / special schools[16]
- £22.5m - Enrichment expansion programme · up to 400 schools · 3 years[15]
- Up to £13m - National Centre for Arts and Music Education · 3 years[8][15]

Product direction

An optional Enrichment Framework layer - not a separate system - will tag activities against the five areas and eight benchmarks; capture outcomes, barriers, adaptations, cost, timing, student voice and partner review; show a simple gaps dashboard; export evidence summaries for leaders and governors; and track participation by cohort with privacy and safeguarding controls.[12]

CCDesigner reduces workload and improves access. It does not replace safeguarding checks or professional due diligence on providers.[15]

Arts Council case wording

CCDesigner provides the practical digital infrastructure through which schools turn the Department for Education's non-statutory Enrichment Framework into consistent action. It connects teachers with trusted arts organisations and Music Hubs, lets high-quality opportunities and resources be added directly to planning, and gives schools a way to evidence access, partnership working, intended outcomes and continuous improvement without creating unnecessary workload.[12][15][19]

09

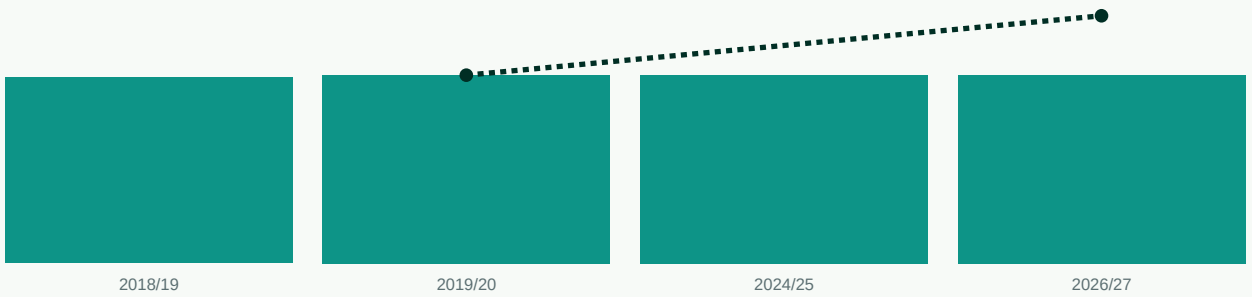
Music Hubs and National Centre

Music Hubs are the local backbone for schools that cannot staff a full music offer alone. Their revenue grant rose into the mid-£70ms in the mid-2010s, then has been held near £76m in cash since 2019 - a significant real-terms cut (Music Mark cites Bank of England: £76m in 2019 ~ £100m today).[21][22] Capital and National Centre support are separate streams, not a like-for-like uplift to that revenue line.

The National Centre is intended to launch by September 2026 and to boost in-school arts enrichment alongside curriculum reform. A separate £22.5 million, three-year enrichment expansion programme targets up to 400 schools - useful evidence of priority, not universal school funding.[8][15]

- £76m - Annual Music Hubs backing to AY 2026/27[7]
- £25m - Additional capital for instruments / technology[7]
- Up to £13m - National Centre for Arts and Music Education over three years[8]
- £22.5m - Enrichment expansion · up to 400 schools · three years[15]

Music Hubs cash stayed near £76m - dotted line is 2019 money today



Cash grant · dotted = 2019 £76m in today's money

Turn It Up; Music Mark / Bank of England: £76m in 2019 ~ £100m today.

> *"When Hub and partner funding is under pressure, CCDesigner makes shared resources go further - improving communication between organisations and teachers, and making use more transparent so funders can see materials reaching cold spots and higher-need schools."*

Current commitments

Annual Hub revenue, one-off capital, and National Centre contract support are not additive like-for-like.

Current national commitments: different funding purposes



Not additive like-for-like. Turn It Up; DfE Enrichment Framework resources.

10

National plans & free resources

The same years that entries fell are also the years government started writing the arts back into national plans.

The Curriculum and Assessment Review treats music as an essential entitlement, commits to a reformed National Curriculum from September 2028, and removes EBacc headline and additional KS4 performance measures from 2025/26 after the Review found they constrained arts and vocational choice.[25][7] Turn It Up (July 2026) sets national action on music education. The National Centre for Arts and Music Education is due to launch September 2026, with online teacher CPD and oversight of Music Hubs from August 2027.[8][7] A four-year SEND / disadvantage music pilot (£2m government, plus £3.85m from Arts Council England and Youth Music) offers free lessons for up to 1,000 pupils; Discover Creative Careers is refreshed with £9m over three years.[7]

Free education resources

Publicly funded or free to schools - each link opens the source:

- Oak National Academy - Music
  https://www.thenational.academy/teachers/key-stages/key-stage-1/subjects/music
- BBC Teach - Primary Music
  https://www.bbc.co.uk/teach/topics/cmjp647k3e8t
- BBC Ten Pieces
  https://www.bbc.co.uk/teach/ten-pieces
- Arts Council England - Music Hubs
  https://www.artscouncil.org.uk/MusicHubs/Guidance
- Youth Music
  https://youthmusic.org.uk/
- Turn It Up: Our plan for music
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/turn-it-up-our-plan-for-music/turn-it-up-our-plan-for-music
- Curriculum and Assessment Review
  https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/curriculum-and-assessment-review-final-report

These programmes fund or publish materials so teachers can use free arts education resources without waiting for local specialist capacity. CCDesigner sits alongside them - helping teachers capture, adapt and share what reaches their libraries and lessons.

> *"Policy is creating space again. CCD turns national plans and free resources into day-to-day classroom use - especially in cold spots - and evidences that greater reach is real, not only announced."*

Plan markers

- EBacc measures - Headline and additional KS4 measures removed from 2025/26[7][25]
- National Curriculum - Reformed music entitlement to be taught from September 2028[7]
- National Centre - Launch Sept 2026; online CPD; Hubs oversight from August 2027[8]
- £76m + £25m - Hub revenue to AY 2026/27 + capital instruments / tech[7]

11

A solution

The picture is uneven, but it is not hopeless - what has been missing is a shared place for the good work, so it can travel.

Creative Curriculum Designer is a free national planning and resource platform for performing and creative arts teachers, from early years to A-level.

Teachers can capture ideas as reusable activity blocks, build lessons, organise into half-term and term plans, and work from a calendar. Partner Hubs connect teachers with arts organisations.

CCD puts shared practice in teachers' hands earlier: greater reach into cold spots, fairer opportunity in lower-participation areas, and clearer communication between schools and cultural partners.

CCD makes funding more transparent by evidencing use of materials. Signed-in accounts show which Partner Hub resources are added to libraries, when activities are built into lessons, and which resources teachers return to.

Music Hubs and arts organisations will be able to track how their resources are being used and where - through IP addresses and login information linked to the signed-in teacher, not a pupil.

Early-years principle: children should help shape their learning. Creative subjects need not always sit in a typical classroom.

> *"The evidence shows fragmentation, cold spots and unequal entitlement. CCD is the practical connection layer - wider reach, shared resources, stronger school-organisation communication, and clearer proof of use so support can follow need."*

How it connects

- Capture - Reusable activity blocks instead of one-off plans
- Plan - Lessons, half-terms and schemes of work in one place
- Connect - Partner Hubs put organisations next to the teacher's library
- Evidence - Signed-in teacher use shows what reaches lessons; Music Hubs and organisations can track how their resources are used and where, through IP address and login linked to that teacher

Capture -> plan -> calendar -> Partner Hubs. CCD shortens the distance between outstanding practice and the teacher who needs it - and shows that colder areas and higher-need schools are part of that reach.

REFERENCES

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